Workflow and Scheduling Optimisation: Fix Visual Effects Ltd

Live client project. Process redesign for a UK visual effects studio scheduling through manually maintained Google Sheets and a JobMatrix.

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BEBA live client project · MSc Business Analysis and Consulting

THE QUESTION

A growing VFX studio schedules work by hand across two disconnected systems, producing duplicate data entry and missed deadlines. What should replace it, and how much change can the studio absorb?

1 The bottleneck is the double entry, not the scheduling logic

Google Sheets schedules and the JobMatrix are maintained separately and by hand. The same production information is entered more than once, which is where the redundancy, the missed deadlines and the coordination overload all originate.

2 Scheduling was modelled as what it actually is

The studio's problem was framed as a flexible job-shop with multi-objective optimisation, and analysed through process mapping and bottleneck analysis under the Theory of Constraints, rather than treated as a software procurement decision.

3 Two redesigns, deliberately at different levels of ambition

A semi-automated model built on Forecast.app with AI support and a human in the loop, preserving creative and operational control; and a fully automated model centralising all production data in Flow Production Tracking with real-time dashboards.

4 The comparison was the deliverable

Both models were assessed through SWOT and returned as prioritised recommendations rather than a single answer, because the right choice depends on how much historical data the studio has and how much control its supervisors are willing to hand over.

METHOD

- **Mixed methods:** qualitative interviews combined with quantitative scheduling analysis
- **Process mapping** of the current JobMatrix and Google Sheets workflow
- **Theory of Constraints** bottleneck identification
- **Flexible job-shop model** with multi-objective optimisation
- **Comparative SWOT** across both proposed redesigns

THE TWO MODELS COMPARED

- **Semi-automated:** Forecast.app as central platform, AI-supported allocation, human in the loop. Retains creative control and flags workload overload early, but needs historical data to predict well.
- **Fully automated:** single capture into Flow Production Tracking, automated data cleaning and workload calculation, real-time dashboards. Eliminates duplicate entry entirely, at the cost of a larger change to how supervisors work.

LIMITATIONS AND HONEST CONSTRAINTS

The semi-automated model depends on sufficient historical data for its predictions to be useful, and that data is exactly what a manual spreadsheet process tends not to preserve cleanly. Neither model was implemented or piloted, so the efficiency gains are projected from process analysis rather than measured. The analysis also treats the studio's stated bottlenecks as accurate; a longer engagement would validate them against actual throughput data before committing to either redesign.

Built with Process mapping · Theory of Constraints · flexible job-shop modelling · SWOT · stakeholder interviews

Delivered current-state process map · bottleneck analysis · two costed redesigns · prioritised recommendations